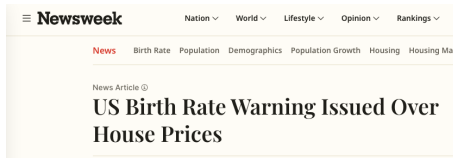


Fertility and Housing Tenure Choice

Tommaso De Santo

05/29/2026

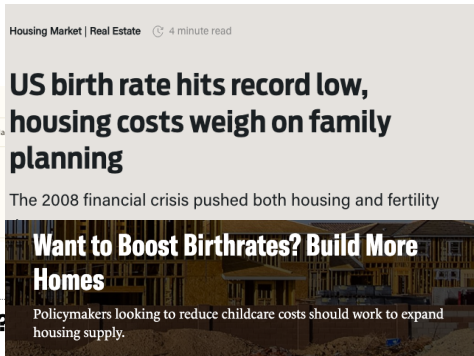
Housing and Fertility



POLICY

Will cheap housing lead to more babies?

The connection between housing and fertility rates has a missing piece.



Renting a home 'leads to lower birth rates'

Housing, Fertility, and Tenure Choice

Housing costs affect fertility, but tenure and wealth matter:

- Owners have more kids when house prices or housing wealth rise; renters do not (Dettling & Kearney 2014)
- Easier mortgage credit raises buying and births jointly, through large-home purchases (Hacamo 2021, Couillard 2025)

Children increase how big of a house you need. This has implications for:

- Owning: tenure segmentation
- Location: housing cost differs geographically
- Wealth: borrowing constraints, bequests

Physical space is key. How much does it affect fertility?

What kind of housing policy is good for natality?

→ focus on space constraints and tenure choice

This Paper

Need a structural model where tenure, location, and fertility are joint. Today:

Model: lifecycle model of fertility, location, tenure, and saving

- Childbirth creates a jump in housing need
- Housing markets with borrowing constraints, tenure choice, transaction costs
- Location and tenure respond to family-space need

Empirics: document facts about fertility, housing, and moving

- ACS: parents live less in the center; role of center-periphery gaps
- PSID: first birth raises ownership, rooms, and moves for space

Goal: write a model disciplining these interactions, think about policy.

Model

Environment

- Two locations: **center** (C) and **periphery** (P) within a metro area
 - Center has an amenity premium but less elastic housing supply
 - Common wages; sorting driven by amenities, housing costs, and moving frictions
- Adult age $a \in [0, J]$; deterministic aging and death
 - Working age $a \in [0, J_R]$; fertile window $a \in [J_f^{\text{start}}, J_f^{\text{end}}]$
 - Children do not work; they depend on their parents
- Households choose:
 - **Fertility**: $n' \in \{0, 1, \dots, \bar{n}\}$, subject to EV shocks
 - **Location**: center or periphery each period (with moving costs and EV shocks)
 - **Tenure**: rent or buy a discrete house size H_k on a housing ladder
 - **Saving**: liquid wealth b with collateral borrowing for owners
- Children age stochastically through life stages; housing need depends on children

Preferences

n : fertility; s : child-aging stage (stochastic); $m = m(n, s)$: children currently at home.

Flow utility. Over consumption and housing services:

$$u(c, \mathbf{h}; m) = \frac{\left[(c - \bar{c}(m))^\alpha (\mathbf{h} - \bar{\mathbf{h}}(m))^{1-\alpha} \right]^{1-\sigma}}{1 - \sigma} + \psi_{\text{child}} m.$$

Subsistence requirements. Depend on family size:

$$\bar{c}(m) = \bar{c}_0 + \bar{c}_1 m, \quad \bar{\mathbf{h}}(m) = \bar{\mathbf{h}}_0 + \underbrace{\bar{h}_{\text{jump}} \mathbf{1}\{m \geq 1\}}_{\text{first-child housing margin}} + \bar{\mathbf{h}}_1 m.$$

Housing services. Households either rent or own; owners get a service premium:

$$\mathbf{h} = \underbrace{\mathbf{1}\{\text{own}\}}_{\text{owner services}} \chi \mathbf{h} + \underbrace{\mathbf{1}\{\text{rent}\}}_{\text{renter services}} \mathbf{h}^R, \quad \chi > 1.$$

- Child costs disappear after children mature.

Bequests

Terminal utility at death:

$$\mathcal{B}(\tilde{b}, n) = \theta_0 (1 + \theta_n n) \frac{(\theta_1 + \tilde{b})^{1-\sigma}}{1-\sigma}, \quad \tilde{b} = b + (1 - \psi)p_i h.$$

- θ_0 governs overall bequest motive (saving level).
- θ_n governs the parent–childless saving differential.
- Total bequeathable wealth $\tilde{b}$ includes housing equity net of the transaction cost for owners.

Housing, Tenure, and Budget Constraints

Households choose housing inputs:

$$h^R \in \{0, H_1^R, \dots, H_{N_R}^R\}, \quad h \in \{0, H_1, \dots, H_{N_H}\}.$$

A household either rents ($h^R > 0, h = 0$) or owns ($h > 0, h^R = 0$).

Tenure segmentation: $\max H_k > \max H_j^R$, so family-sized housing is reachable only through ownership.

Renters ($h = 0$)

$$b' = qb + y(a) - c - r_i h^R, \quad b' \geq 0.$$

Owners ($h^R = 0$), with prior owner stock h_{-1}

$$b' = qb + y(a) - c - (\delta + \tau_H) p_i h - \mathbf{1}\{h \neq h_{-1}\} [p_i h - (1 - \psi) p_i h_{-1}], \quad b' \geq -\phi p_i h.$$

- q : gross bond rate; δ : depreciation; τ_H : property tax; ψ : transaction cost.
- Movers and newly matured children arrive as renters, then re-choose.

Fertility and Child Aging

- Fertility choices are made only in the fertile window $a \in [J_f^{\text{start}}, J_f^{\text{end}}]$.
- One-shot fertility: can have multiple kids, but choose only once:

$$n' \in \{0, 1, \dots, \bar{n}\}.$$

- After birth, children age through stages s (think toddler $\rightarrow$ child $\rightarrow$ teen $\rightarrow$ adult):
 - Aging is **sequential**: each stage transitions only to the next one, with random arrival
 - All n' children of a parent **together** as a single cohort — s is shared.
- While children are at home ($s < \text{matured}$), they raise housing need $\bar{h}(m)$ and consumption cost $\bar{c}(m)$.
- Once matured, child costs shut off and children enter the economy at age $a = 0$.

Firms and Earnings

- Competitive firms produce with labor:

$$Y = AL, \quad w = A.$$

- Common wages** across locations: sorting driven entirely by amenities and housing costs.
- Age-dependent earnings:

$$y(a) = \begin{cases} (1 - \tau_{\text{pay}}) w(a) & a < J_R \\ \bar{b} & a \geq J_R \end{cases}$$

- Retirees receive a stationary pay-as-you-go pension $\bar{b}$ financed by payroll taxes.

Housing Supply and Price Mapping

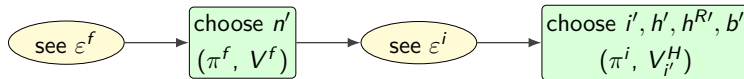
Housing supply in each location:

$$H_i^s(r_i) = \bar{r}_i r_i^{\eta_i}, \quad i \in \{C, P\}.$$

- Less elastic center supply makes family space more expensive in the core.
- House prices map into user costs through

$$r_i = (q + \delta + \tau_H)p_i.$$

The Household's Problem



State.

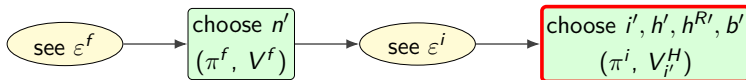
$$x = (b, h, i, a, n, s), \quad h \in \{0, H_1, \dots, H_{N_H}\}.$$

- b : liquid wealth; h : owner-occupied size ($h = 0$ if renter); i : location; a : age.
- n : fertility; s : child-aging stage.
- After the fertility choice, n' is the period's fertility state; if no birth, $n' = n$.

Within the period: choose n' , then $(i', h', h^{R'}, b')$.

A renter sets $h' = 0$; an owner sets $h^{R'} = 0$.

The Household's Problem: Housing and Saving



Conditional on destination i' :

$$V_{i'}^H(b, h, i, a, n', s) = \max_{h', h^{R'}, b'} u(c, \chi h' + h^{R'}; m(n', s)) + \beta \mathbb{E}_{s'} [V(b', h', i', a + 1, n', s')]$$

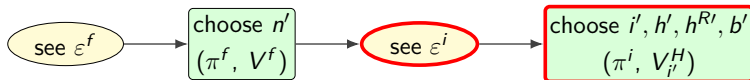
- Owner stock $h' \in \{0, H_1, \dots, H_{N_H}\}$; rental flow $h^{R'} \in \{0, H_1^R, \dots, H_{N_R}^R\}$.
- Adjustment indicator $\tau = \mathbf{1}\{h' \neq h \text{ or } i' \neq i\}$.

Budget and collateral.

$$c + b' + r_{i'} h^{R'} + (\delta + \tau_H) p_{i'} h' = qb + y(a) - \tau [p_{i'} h' - (1 - \psi) p_i h],$$

$$b' \geq -\phi p_{i'} h'.$$

The Household's Problem: Location Choice



After fertility choice n' , draw destination taste shocks $\varepsilon_{i'}^i$ and choose a destination. Let

$$\tilde{V}_{i'} = V_{i'}^H(b, h, i, a, n', s) + E_{i'}^R - \mu_{ii'}.$$

The location object is the expected maximum over those shocks:

$$\begin{aligned} V^i(b, h, i, a, n', s) &\equiv \mathbb{E}_{\varepsilon_i} \max_{i' \in \{C, P\}} \{ \tilde{V}_{i'} + \varepsilon_{i'}^i \} \\ &\propto \kappa_i \ln \sum_{i' \in \{C, P\}} \exp\left(\frac{\tilde{V}_{i'}}{\kappa_i}\right). \end{aligned}$$

- $V_{i'}^H$ maximizes over $(h', h^{R'}, b')$ in destination i' .

Choice probabilities:

$$\pi_{i'}^i(b, h, i, a, n', s) = \frac{\exp(\tilde{V}_{i'}/\kappa_i)}{\sum_{j \in \{C, P\}} \exp(\tilde{V}_j/\kappa_i)}.$$

The Household's Problem: Fertility Choice



Childless households in the fertile window choose fertility once:

$$\begin{aligned} V(b, h, i, a, 0, 0) &\equiv \mathbb{E}_{\varepsilon^f} \max_{n' \in \mathcal{N}} \{ V^i(b, h, i, a, n', s(n')) + \varepsilon_{n'}^f \} \\ &= \kappa_n \ln \sum_{n' \in \mathcal{N}} \exp \left(\frac{V^i(b, h, i, a, n', s(n'))}{\kappa_n} \right). \end{aligned}$$

Choice probabilities:

$$\pi_{n'}^f(b, h, i, a, 0, 0) = \frac{\exp(V^i(b, h, i, a, n', s(n'))/\kappa_n)}{\sum_{n''} \exp(V^i(b, h, i, a, n'', s(n''))/\kappa_n)}.$$

Young-Adult Entry and Stationary Scale

Shares & Prob

- **City scale** S : total adult population mass
- Each period, two pools of potential entrants:
 - City-born flow: SB_0 (incumbents' mature children)
 - Outside-origin pool: M (fixed in counterfactuals)
- Each potential entrant picks C , P , or outside; EV-I tastes, scale κ_E
- Entering $i \in \{C, P\}$: childless renter at value W_i^E ; outside value $\bar{W}^E$
- City entry probability (from EV shocks): $q^E = \pi_C^E + \pi_P^E$
- Actual entrants at i : $E_i = (M + SB_0) \pi_i^E$
- Per-unit replacement E_0 : entrants needed per unit of S to keep g stationary = per-unit deaths
- **Stationarity**: $q^E(M + SB_0) = SE_0 \Rightarrow S = \frac{q^E M}{E_0 - q^E B_0}$
- At baseline: normalize $S = 1$, target $q^{E,*}$; E_0 , B_0 from equilibrium; $\bar{W}^E$, M residual

Summary

- A model of fertility, location, tenure, and saving
- Children raise housing need, with implications for tenure and location choice
- The sorting wedge between parents and childless rises with the local rent gap
- The closer a household is to being space-constrained, the more costly a child is
- Some predictions:
 - Parents sort peripheral, and are more likely to own
 - Sorting strengthens with the local rent gap
- The data can help:
 - Improve our understanding of housing and fertility
 - Validate the predictions
 - Inform our quantification

Empirics

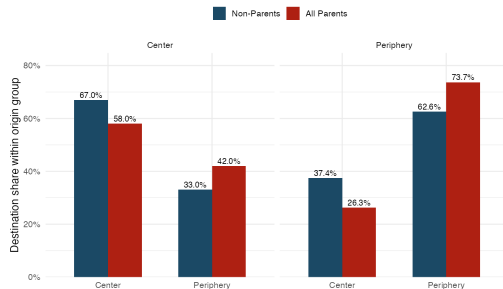
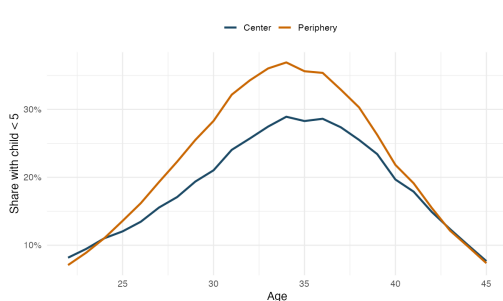
Data

- **American Community Survey (ACS) 1-year estimates:**
 - Annual survey data collected by the U.S. Census Bureau
 - Geographic detail up to PUMA level
 - Demographic characteristics, socioeconomic indicators, and housing information
- **Panel Study of Income Dynamics (PSID):**
 - Longitudinal household survey initiated in 1968 (24,000 households in 2021)
 - Follows original sample families and their descendants across generations
 - Rich demographics, income and wealth information
 - Work on geocoded files in progress

Parenthood, Location, and Within-Metro Moves

[Details](#)[Geography](#)[Regressions](#)[Within moves](#)

Parents live less in the center, and movers re-sort away from the center.

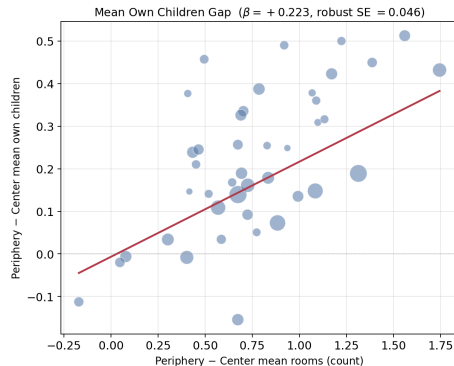
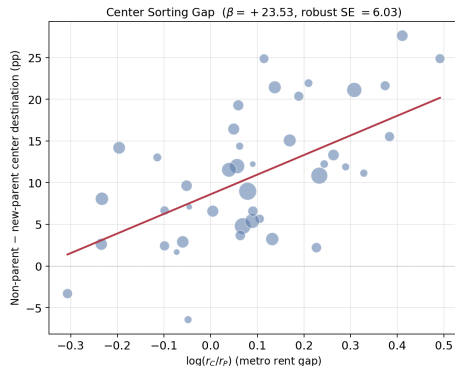


ACS 2012–2023. Baseline center shares: 49.4% for non-parents, 41.6% for new parents.

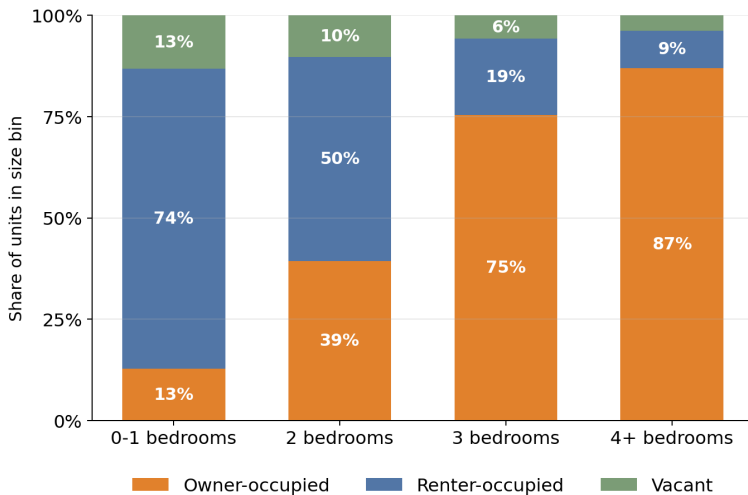
Cross-Metro Sorting and Family Space

[Details](#)[Regression](#)[Elasticity](#)[Stock](#)

Where cores are costly and periphery units are larger, family outcomes diverge spatially.



Big Units Are Owned



Using the PSID: Event-Study Design

For household i , let E_i denote the year of childbirth. For any housing outcome Y_{it} , estimate

$$Y_{it} = \sum_{k=-5, k \neq -2}^{10} \alpha_k \mathbf{1}\{t - E_i = k\} + \zeta_i + \tau_t + \delta X_{it} + \varepsilon_{it}.$$

- ζ_i and τ_t are household and calendar-year fixed effects.
- The omitted period is $k = -2$, so each α_k is relative to two years before birth.
- I use the same design for homeownership, moving-for-size, and rooms.
- Geocoded data analysis in progress.

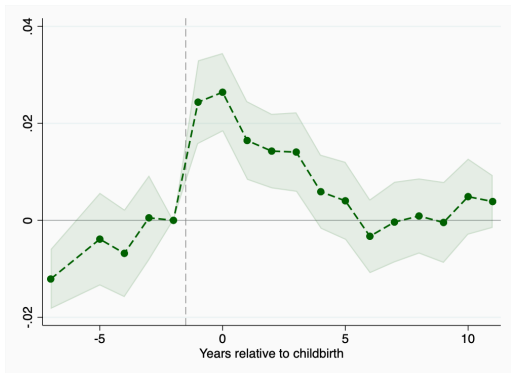
PSID: Childbirth Raises Moves for Space

Reasons

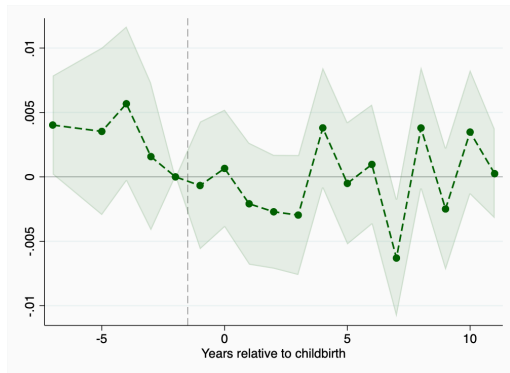
By Category

$\hat{\alpha}_k$: change in probability of moving for reason Y , relative to $k = -2$.

$Y = \mathbf{1}\{\text{moved for expansion of housing}\}$



$Y = \mathbf{1}\{\text{moved for neighborhood quality}\}$



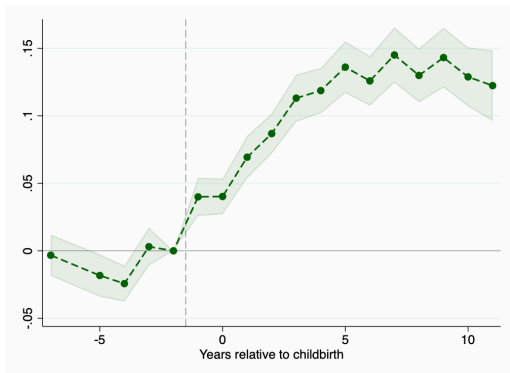
- The probability of moving for housing size rises around first birth.
- By contrast, moves for neighborhood quality do not rise in the same way.

PSID: Ownership and Housing Size Around First Birth

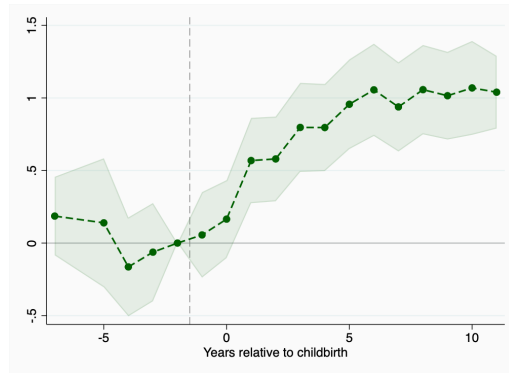
[Details](#)

Model: $\bar{h}(1) > \bar{h}(0)$; kids raise ownership. $\hat{\alpha}_k$: change relative to $k = -2$.

$$Y_{it} = \mathbf{1}\{\text{owner}\}_{it}$$



$$Y_{it} = \text{number of rooms}_{it}$$



- Homeownership rises sharply after first birth; rooms expand by about 0.66 at $k = +3$.

Pre-birth mean: 6.0 rooms.

Quantification

Externally Calibrated Parameters

	Param	Description	Value	Source
<i>Pref.</i>	σ	Risk aversion	2.0	–
	$\bar{c}_0$	Consumption floor	0.10	Poverty line
<i>Fin.</i>	q	Gross bond rate	1.04	–
	δ	Depreciation	0.02	Greaney et al. (2024)
	τ_H	Property tax	0.01	US average
	ϕ	LTV limit	0.80	20% down payment
	ψ	Transaction cost	0.06	Greaney et al. (2024)
<i>Life</i>	J, J_R	Lifespan, retirement	60, 47	Ages 18–77, ret. 65
	τ_{pay}	Payroll tax	0.179	Greaney et al. (2024)
<i>Housing</i>	η_P, η_C	Supply elasticities	2.0, 0.8	Saiz (2010)

Internally Calibrated Parameters

Strategy

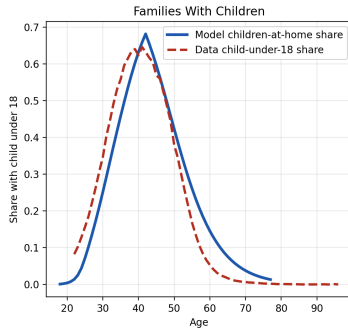
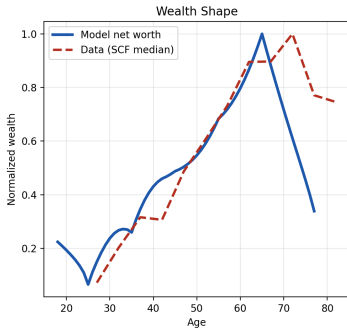
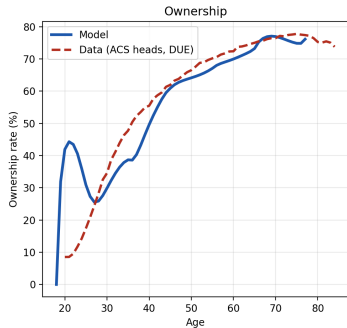
Param	Description	Value
$\mathcal{E}_C$	Center amenity	0.140
$\bar{r}_C$	Center rent anchor	0.096
α	Consumption weight	0.871
β	Discount factor	0.953
b_0	Entry wealth	0.398
χ	Owner utility premium	1.298
ψ_{child}	Flow utility of children	0.071
κ_f	Fertility Gumbel scale	3.816
$\bar{h}_0$	Baseline housing need	3.231
$\bar{h}_{\text{jump}}$	Housing jump (1st child)	0.986
$\bar{h}_n$	Add'l child housing cost	0.548
$\bar{c}_n$	Add'l-child cons. cost	0.110
κ_i	Location-choice Gumbel scale	1.448
μ_{move}	Moving cost	4.140
θ_0	Bequest shifter	0.595
θ_n	Bequest parent premium	0.352

Calibration Targets

	Moment	Target	Model
<i>Fertility</i>	TFR	1.700	1.770
	Ever childless	0.150	0.191
	Age at first birth	26.0	34.0
	Fertility gradient $P-C$	0.133	0.166
<i>Housing</i>	Ownership, ages 30–55	0.575	0.684
	Ownership gradient $P-C$	0.186	0.107
	H_{01} (PSID, rooms)	0.664	1.261
	H_{12} (PSID, rooms)	0.566	0.379
	Parent ownership gap	0.168	0.185
	Housing exp. share	0.240	0.251
<i>Saving</i>	Liq. wealth / income	0.600	0.443
<i>Location</i>	Center population share	0.450	0.425
	Rent/room ratio C/P	1.140	1.184
	Center share, non-parents	0.494	0.373
	Center share, new parents	0.416	0.361
	C–P switching rate	0.032	0.044
<i>Bequest</i>	Ownership, ages 65–75	0.764	0.767
	Parent–childless own gap	0.070	0.036

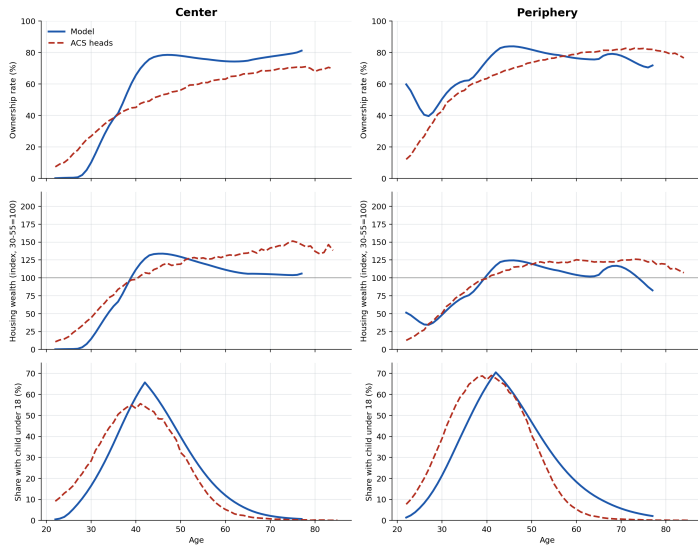
Lifecycle Fit

Housing Fit

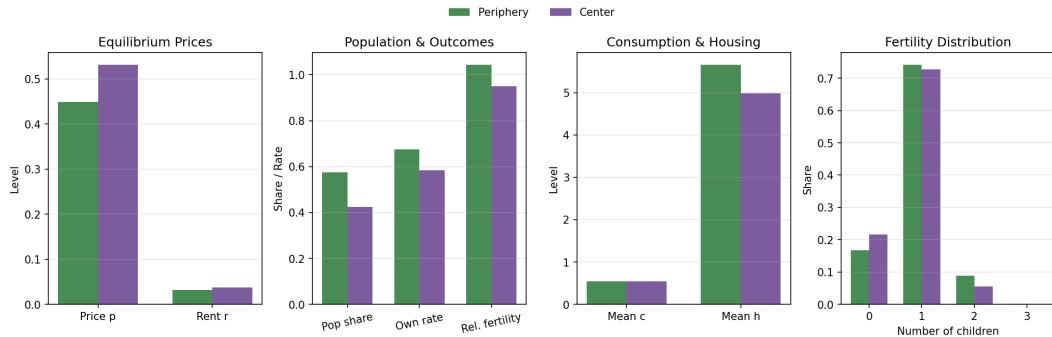


Spatial Lifecycle Fit

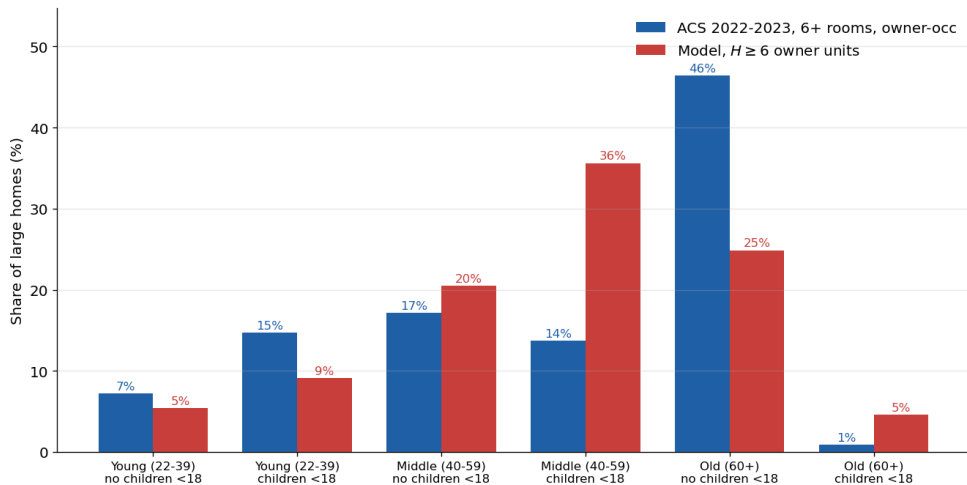
Aggregate Wealth



Equilibrium



Intergenerational Allocation: Model vs Data



Owner-occupied units with ≥ 6 rooms. Heads of household, ACS 2022–2023.

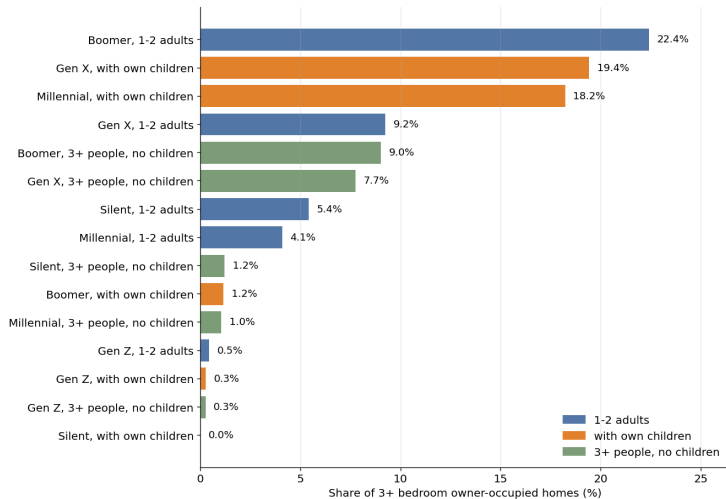
Conclusion

- A model of fertility with realistic housing and lifecycle
- Trying to capture the many implications of children's impact on housing demand
- Aim is policy. Want to increase fertility: Can housing help? What costs?
- More work is needed:
 - Theory: important to understand the role of constraints and sorting incentives. Can we say something about policy design?
 - Financial constraints
 - Size supply and allocation of family space
 - Empirically: use new geocoded data to track location and moves
 - Quantification: use the model to evaluate policies that target housing to parents, and understand the channels

Thank You

Appendix

Appendix: Who Owns America's Large Homes?

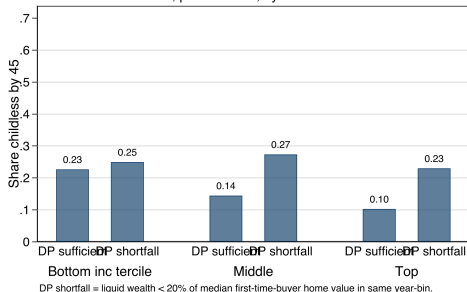
[Back](#)

ACS 2022–2023, household heads, owner-occupied 3+ bedroom units. Generations defined by birth year. “With own children” uses youngest-child age < 18.

Appendix: PSID – Wealth Gate on Childlessness

Shortfall: renter's liquid wealth $< 0.035 \times P_t^{\text{target}}$, where P_t^{target} is the median first-time-buyer home value (the FHA 3.5% DP floor).

Renters who lack the 20% down payment remain childless more
PSID renters at 25-30, pre-first-birth, by DP shortfall and income tercile



PSID renters 25–30, pre-first-birth, $N = 2,961$. Shortfall renters are 8.8 pp more childless by 45, controlling for log income and log NW ($p = 0.003$).

Appendix: PSID – Wealth Gate Works Through Large Homes

Shortfall: as defined on previous slide. **Joint:** $1\{\text{first purchase by 40} \cap \text{first birth by 40}\}$, split by home size at purchase.

	(1) joint, any	(2) joint, large (≥ 4 rooms)	(3) joint, small (< 4 rooms)
Shortfall	-0.097** (0.047)	-0.092* (0.047)	-0.005 (0.014)
log income	0.100*** (0.022)	0.112*** (0.021)	-0.012 (0.009)
log net worth	-0.007 (0.005)	-0.007 (0.005)	0.000 (0.001)
Observations	1,554	1,554	1,554
R^2	0.031	0.035	0.003

PSID renters 25–30, pre-first-birth, followed to 40. PSID weights, robust SE in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$,

** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Appendix: Sorting and Housing-Demand Elasticity

$\mathcal{E}_C > \mathcal{E}_P$ (amenity); $r_C > r_P$ (rents); $M = qb + y - b'$ (expenditure budget);

$\bar{h}(n)$ housing requirement with n children, $\bar{h}(1) > \bar{h}(0)$. Ignoring moving costs and Gumbel

Sorting.

- Higher $\bar{h} \Rightarrow$ larger rent bill in $C \Rightarrow$ preference for C falls.
- Single crossing: for each M , unique threshold $\hat{h}(M)$ s.t. $\bar{h} < \hat{h} \Rightarrow C$, $\bar{h} > \hat{h} \Rightarrow P$.
- $\hat{h}$ rises with M (richer households absorb high r_C).
- Since $\bar{h}(1) > \bar{h}(0)$: parents sort weakly peripheral.
 - Parent share falls with local rent.
 - First birth triggers moves to lower- r areas.

Elasticity. Housing demand for uncapped renter splits into committed + discretionary:

$$h^*(n) = \underbrace{\alpha \bar{h}(n)}_{\text{committed}} + \underbrace{\frac{(1-\alpha)(M-\bar{c})}{r}}_{\text{discretionary}}.$$

- Parents less income-elastic on intensive margin; less responsive to rent.
- Kids raise the probability of owning.

- In this static derivation, let $\mathcal{V}_i(n; M)$ be indirect utility for a renter with n children in location i .
- $\Delta\mathcal{V}(n; M) \equiv \mathcal{V}_C(n; M) - \mathcal{V}_P(n; M)$
- Sorting wedge: $\mathcal{W}(M) \equiv \Delta\mathcal{V}(0; M) - \Delta\mathcal{V}(1; M) > 0$
- If the rent gap $r_C - r_P$ widens, the parent-childless gap in location preferences $\mathcal{W}$ widens:

$$\left. \frac{\partial \mathcal{W}}{\partial r_C} \right|_{r_P} > 0.$$

- Across cities: the parent-childless center-share gap rises with the local center-periphery rent gap.

Appendix: Constrained Squeeze

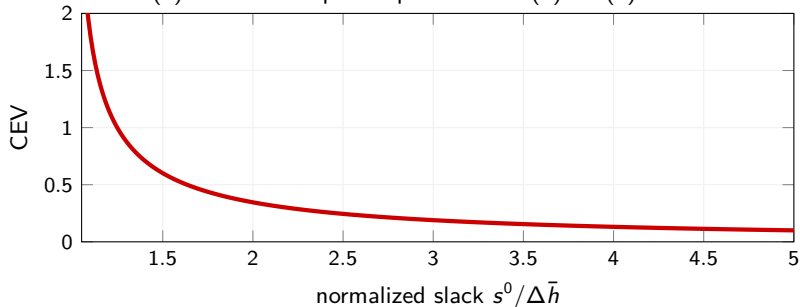
derivation

Capped renters and owners on a fixed rung cannot adjust housing. How costly is a child on a home that barely fits one?

Consumption-equivalent variation, holding housing fixed:

$$u(c + \text{CEV}, h, 1) = u(c, h, 0).$$

Pre-birth slack $s^0 = h - \bar{h}(0)$ and extra required space $\Delta \bar{h} = \bar{h}(1) - \bar{h}(0)$.



Appendix: Entry Shares and City-Entry Probability

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- Potential entrant draws EV-I tastes over $\{C, P, \text{outside}\}$ with scale κ_E
- Modeled-location values W_C^E , W_P^E (from solving as childless renters at $(b^E, R, i, 0, 0, 0)$); outside value $\bar{W}^E$
- Logit shares:

$$\pi_i^E = \frac{\exp(W_i^E / \kappa_E)}{\exp(W_C^E / \kappa_E) + \exp(W_P^E / \kappa_E) + \exp(\bar{W}^E / \kappa_E)}, \quad i \in \{C, P\}$$

$$\pi_{\text{out}}^E = \frac{\exp(\bar{W}^E / \kappa_E)}{\exp(W_C^E / \kappa_E) + \exp(W_P^E / \kappa_E) + \exp(\bar{W}^E / \kappa_E)}$$

- Sum to one: $\pi_C^E + \pi_P^E + \pi_{\text{out}}^E = 1$
- **City entry probability:** $q^E = \pi_C^E + \pi_P^E = 1 - \pi_{\text{out}}^E$
- π_i^E determines *where* entrants go inside the city; q^E determines *how many* enter

Appendix: Entry Accounting Algorithm

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1. Solve the benchmark in normalized units: $S^* = 1$. The normalized composition gives E_{0C}^* , E_{0P}^* , $E_0^* = E_{0C}^* + E_{0P}^*$, and B_0^* .

2. Pick the benchmark outside margin. Choose $\bar{W}^E$ so that entry probabilities satisfy

$$q^{E,*} = \pi_C^{E,*} + \pi_P^{E,*}.$$

3. Use the aggregate stationarity equation at $S^* = 1$ to recover the outside-origin potential entrant mass:

$$M = \frac{E_0^*}{q^{E,*}} - B_0^*.$$

4. The solve must also reproduce entry by location:

$$SE_{0i} = [M + SB_0] \pi_i^E, \quad i \in \{C, P\}.$$

The scalar equation for S is the sum of these two conditions.

5. In counterfactuals, keep $(M, \bar{W}^E, \kappa_E)$ fixed. Recompute household values, E_0 , B_0 , and q^E , then set

$$S = \frac{q^E M}{E_0 - q^E B_0}, \quad E_i = [M + SB_0] \pi_i^E.$$

Appendix: Distributional Stationarity

- The stationary object is the normalized composition g together with city scale S . The level mass of any household state is Sg .
- Incumbent households transition through policies, fertility, location choice, aging, and death.
- Location-specific entrant masses are

$$E_i = [M + SB_0] \pi_i^E, \quad i \in \{C, P\}.$$

These entrants are placed at the entrant states x_i^E .

- The scalar equation for S is only the sum of the two entry-location equations. The equilibrium still has to reproduce the location distribution inside g .

Calibration Strategy

Externally set

- Lifecycle structure, taxes, interest rate
- Collateral ($\phi = 0.80$), transaction cost ($\psi = 0.06$)
- Housing ladder and supply elasticities
- Five owner sizes at $\{5.2, 5.85, 6.55, 7.55, 9.0\}$ rooms; rental cap at 4.8 rooms.
- Bequests parameterized by (θ_0, θ_n) with fixed $\theta_1 = 0.01$.

Internally calibrated (SMM)

- 15 parameters: 2 inverted (amenity, rent anchor) + 13 searched
- Fertility, tenure, mobility, saving, bequests
- 17 target moments from ACS and PSID

Appendix: Setup — Utility, Demands, Indirect Utility

[back](#)

Common preliminaries for the derivations that follow.

Utility (CRRA over Cobb–Douglas Stone–Geary):

$$u(c, h; m) = \frac{[(c - \bar{c}(m))^\alpha (h - \bar{h}(m))^{1-\alpha}]^{1-\sigma}}{1 - \sigma}.$$

Interior demands (σ -invariant). With M household resources, rent r_i in location i , and $\tilde{M}_i(\bar{h}) = M - \bar{c} - r_i \bar{h}$:

$$c^* - \bar{c} = \alpha \tilde{M}_i, \quad h^* - \bar{h} = (1 - \alpha) \tilde{M}_i / r_i.$$

Indirect utility with amenity $\mathcal{E}_i$:

$$\mathcal{V}_i(\bar{h}; M) = \frac{Z^*(\bar{h}; M, r_i)^{1-\sigma}}{1 - \sigma} + \mathcal{E}_i, \quad Z^* = \alpha^\alpha (1 - \alpha)^{1-\alpha} \tilde{M}_i r_i^{-(1-\alpha)}.$$

Appendix: Sorting Derivation [back](#)

For $r_C > r_P$, $\mathcal{E}_C > \mathcal{E}_P$, define $\Delta\mathcal{V}(\bar{h}; M) = \mathcal{V}_C(\bar{h}; M) - \mathcal{V}_P(\bar{h}; M)$.

Derivative. With $\gamma \equiv \alpha + \sigma(1 - \alpha) > 0$ and $\kappa \equiv \alpha^\alpha(1 - \alpha)^{1-\alpha}$,

$$\frac{d\Delta\mathcal{V}}{d\bar{h}} = -\kappa^{1-\sigma} \left[\frac{r_C^\gamma}{\tilde{M}_C^\sigma} - \frac{r_P^\gamma}{\tilde{M}_P^\sigma} \right] < 0.$$

Sign. $r_C > r_P$ implies $r_C^\gamma > r_P^\gamma$; $\tilde{M}_C < \tilde{M}_P$ implies $\tilde{M}_C^{-\sigma} > \tilde{M}_P^{-\sigma}$. Both factors favour C, so the bracket is strictly positive and the derivative is strictly negative.

Threshold. Since $\Delta\mathcal{V}$ is continuous and strictly decreasing in $\bar{h}$, the equation $\Delta\mathcal{V}(\hat{h}; M) = 0$ has at most one solution. Existence on a non-degenerate interval follows from $\Delta\mathcal{V}(0; M) > 0$ (amenity-positive) and $\Delta\mathcal{V}(\bar{h}; M) \rightarrow -\infty$ as $\bar{h} \uparrow (M - \bar{c})/r_C$ (infeasibility in C). Unique threshold $\hat{h}(M)$.

Parent-childless ordering. $\bar{h}(1) > \bar{h}(0)$ and $\Delta\mathcal{V}$ strictly decreasing $\Rightarrow$ parents weakly prefer the periphery, strictly when $\bar{h}(0) < \hat{h}(M) < \bar{h}(1)$.

Appendix: Elasticity-Attenuation Derivation

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Simplified demand (interior renter at rent r ; assume $\bar{c}(0) = \bar{c}(1) = \bar{c}$ so that only the housing requirement varies with the number of children):

$$h^*(n) = \alpha \bar{h}(n) + (1 - \alpha) \frac{M - \bar{c}}{r}.$$

Elasticities.

$$e_M(n) = \frac{\partial \log h^*}{\partial \log M} = \frac{(1 - \alpha)(M - \bar{c})}{r h^*(n)}, \quad e_r(n) = \frac{\partial \log h^*}{\partial \log r} = - \frac{(1 - \alpha)(M - \bar{c})}{r h^*(n)}.$$

Attenuation. $h^*(n)$ is strictly increasing in $\bar{h}(n)$ (coefficient $\alpha > 0$); the numerator is independent of $\bar{h}(n)$. Hence both $e_M(n)$ and $|e_r(n)|$ are strictly decreasing in $\bar{h}(n)$. Since $\bar{h}(1) > \bar{h}(0)$:

$$e_M(1) < e_M(0), \quad |e_r(1)| < |e_r(0)|.$$

Limits. As $\bar{h} \rightarrow 0$, both elasticities $\rightarrow \mp 1$ (Cobb–Douglas benchmark). As $\bar{h} \rightarrow (M - \bar{c})/r$ (feasibility boundary), both $\rightarrow 0$ (pure subsistence).

Identification. The gap $e_M(0) - e_M(1) > 0$ pins down $\Delta \bar{h} = \bar{h}(1) - \bar{h}(0)$ given α , $M - \bar{c}$, and r .

Appendix: Cross-Metro Sorting-Wedge Derivation

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Indirect utility on an interior renter branch in location i with n children ($\sigma = 1$ for transparency; signs go through for any $\sigma > 0$):

$$\mathcal{V}_i(n; M) = \log \tilde{M}_i^n - (1 - \alpha) \log r_i + \mathcal{E}_i, \quad \tilde{M}_i^n = M - \bar{c}(n) - r_i \bar{h}(n).$$

Sorting wedge. Define $\Delta \mathcal{V}(n; M) = \mathcal{V}_C(n; M) - \mathcal{V}_P(n; M)$ and $\mathcal{W}(M) \equiv \Delta \mathcal{V}(0; M) - \Delta \mathcal{V}(1; M)$:

$$\mathcal{W}(M) = \log \frac{\tilde{M}_C^0 \tilde{M}_P^1}{\tilde{M}_C^1 \tilde{M}_P^0}.$$

Comparative statics in rents. Using $\partial \tilde{M}_i^n / \partial r_i = -\bar{h}(n)$,

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{W}}{\partial r_C} = \frac{\delta_h(M - \bar{c}(0)) + \bar{h}(0) \delta_c}{\tilde{M}_C^1 \tilde{M}_C^0} > 0, \quad \frac{\partial \mathcal{W}}{\partial r_P} = -\frac{\delta_h(M - \bar{c}(0)) + \bar{h}(0) \delta_c}{\tilde{M}_P^1 \tilde{M}_P^0} < 0.$$

Numerators positive by interior feasibility ($M > \bar{c}(0)$) plus $\delta_c, \delta_h, \bar{h}(0) > 0$; denominators positive on the interior renter branch.

Reading. Raising the centre rent (or lowering the periphery rent) widens the parent-childless sorting wedge: the cross-metro elasticity of sorting strength to the local rent gap is strictly positive. Same algebraic structure carries through for capped renters (replace $\tilde{M}_i^n$ with $\check{M}_i^n = M - r_i \bar{h}_R - \bar{c}(n)$).

Appendix: Constrained-Squeeze CEV Derivation

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CEV solves $u(c, h, 0) = u(c + \text{CEV}, h, 1)$: housing quantity is held fixed at h , and the post-child surplus shrinks via $\bar{h}(n)$ from $s^0 = h - \bar{h}(0)$ to $s^0 - \Delta\bar{h} = h - \bar{h}(1)$. Under Stone–Geary $u = [(c - \bar{c}(n))^\alpha (h - \bar{h}(n))^{1-\alpha}]^{1-\sigma} / (1 - \sigma)$ and $\bar{c}(0) = \bar{c}(1) = \bar{c}$, equating utilities:

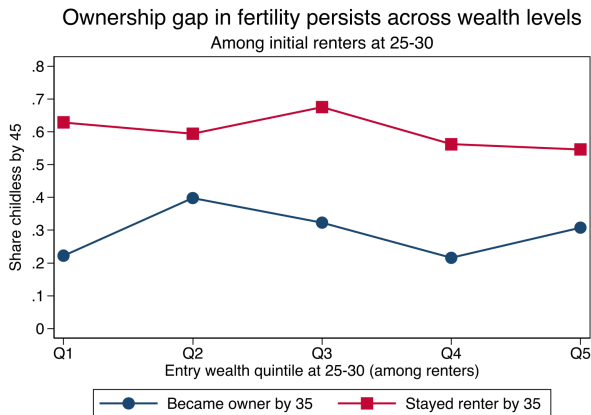
$$(c - \bar{c})^\alpha (s^0)^{1-\alpha} = (c + \text{CEV} - \bar{c})^\alpha (s^0 - \Delta\bar{h})^{1-\alpha}.$$

Rearrange:

$$\frac{c + \text{CEV} - \bar{c}}{c - \bar{c}} = \left(\frac{s^0}{s^0 - \Delta\bar{h}} \right)^{(1-\alpha)/\alpha} \implies \text{CEV} = (c - \bar{c}) \left[\left(\frac{s^0}{s^0 - \Delta\bar{h}} \right)^{(1-\alpha)/\alpha} - 1 \right].$$

Ownership Is the Binding Constraint on Fertility

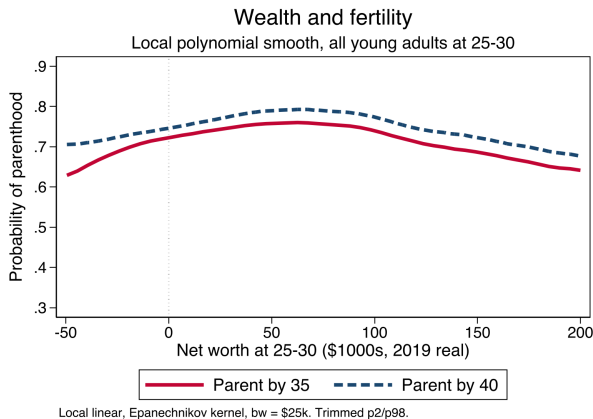
Aggregate Gap



Sample: PSID renters at ages 25–30, pre-first-birth, followed to age 45 ($N = 1,127$).

- At **every** wealth quintile, renters who transition to ownership by 35 are 20–35 pp less likely to remain childless by 45.
- The gap does not shrink with wealth: even wealthy renters who do not buy remain $\sim 55\%$ childless.
- Mediation regression: wealth has **zero** direct effect on fertility ($p = 0.92$): the entire effect runs

Wealth and Fertility: Two Channels

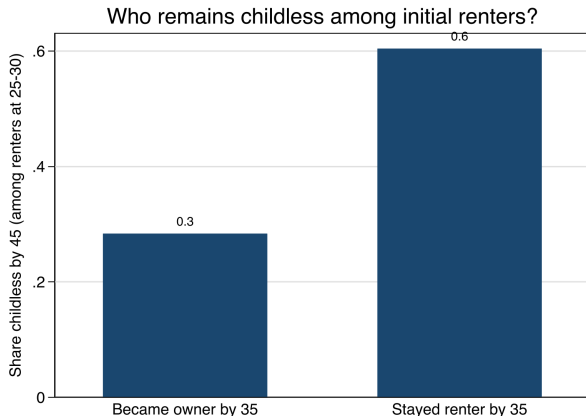


The unconditional wealth–fertility relationship is **hump-shaped**:

- **Rising part** ($NW < \$80k$):
more wealth $\Rightarrow$ can clear down payment $\Rightarrow$ access family-sized housing $\Rightarrow$ have children. The *resource/housing channel*.
- **Falling part** ($NW > \$80k$):
wealthier young adults are disproportionately high human capital and career-invested. The *opportunity cost channel*.

The non-monotonicity is why we need

Aggregate Ownership Transition Gap

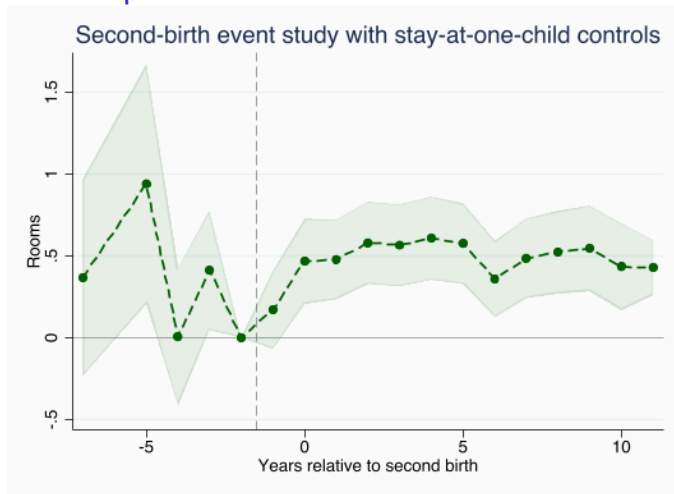
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Among renters at 25–30 who have not yet had a first child:

- Those who transition to ownership by 35: **28%** childless at 45.
- Those who stay renters through 35: **60%** childless at 45.
- A **32 pp** extensive-margin gap—larger than any within-tenure wealth effect.

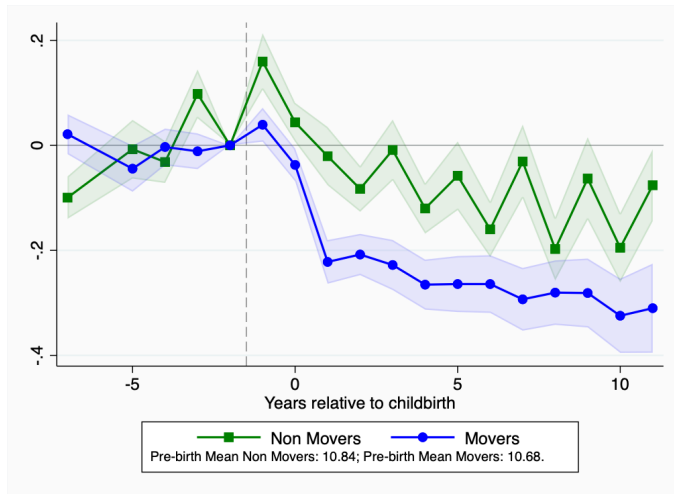
Tenure status averaged over ages 25–30 (renter) and 31–35 (transition outcome). Childlessness measured by 45 using reported age at first birth.

PSID: Housing Also Expands After Second Birth

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Baseline second-birth event study with stay-at-one-child controls: the +3 coefficient is about **0.57 rooms**.

PSID: Income Trajectories, Movers vs Non-Movers



Defining Center and Periphery Within Large Metros

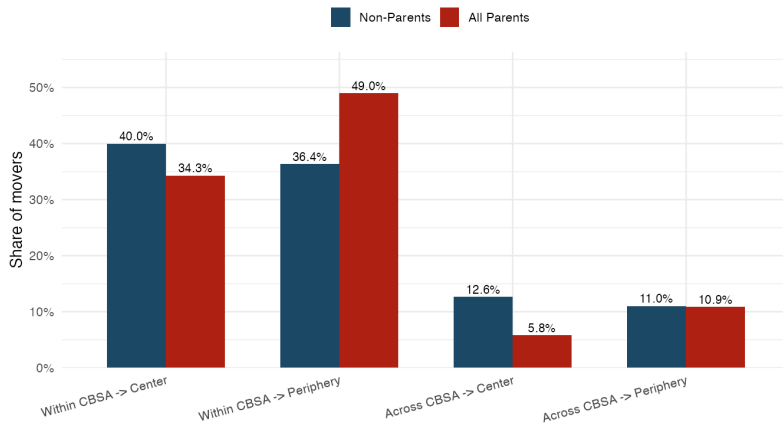
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- 51 metros with year-2000 population above 1 million.
- Rank tracts by distance to the CBD; the core is the closest 10% of metro population.
- Aggregate tracts to PUMAs via centroids and tract population.
- PUMA is *center* if $\geq 50\%$ of its population sits in core tracts, *periphery* if $< 10\%$, *middle* otherwise.
- Binary split: middle PUMAs go to center. Center share: 45%.

Source: ACS 2012–2023, PUMA-level.

Most Adjustment Is Within Metros

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- Most adjustment happens **within** metros rather than across metros.

Mover Regressions: Parent vs. Non-Parent

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Outcome (pp)	(1) New Parent	(2) Any Parent
Across-CBSA move	−4.56*** (0.78)	−5.17*** (0.54)
Center destination within-CBSA	−11.21*** (0.66)	−11.44*** (0.53)
Within CBSA → Center	−6.77*** (0.77)	−6.79*** (0.65)
Within CBSA → Periphery	11.33*** (0.49)	11.95*** (0.30)
Center dest. center origin	−9.69*** (0.81)	−8.91*** (0.53)
Center dest. periphery origin	−10.71*** (0.51)	−11.32*** (0.47)
Age and year FE	Yes	Yes
Sex and race controls	Yes	Yes

Notes. OLS on ACS 2012–2023 within-metro movers, ages 22–45, weighted by *perwt*. Coefficients in percentage points. Column (1) uses a *new-parent* indicator (eldest child < 4); column (2) uses an *any-parent* indicator. Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Cross-Metro Sorting Regression

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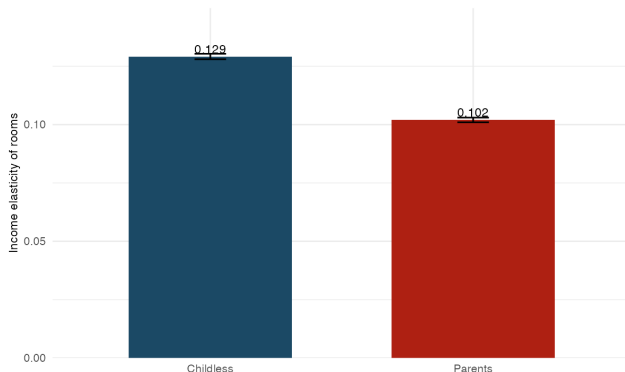
Dependent gap (pp)	Slope on log rent gap	Metros
Center-share gap	6.23 (5.19)	42
Center-destination gap within-CBSA movers	23.53*** (6.18)	42

Notes. Unit of observation is the metro. Each dependent variable is the non-parent minus new-parent gap in percentage points. Regressor is the local log center-periphery rent-per-room gap. Each regression is weighted by its corresponding metro sample size. *** $p < 0.01$.

Housing Demand Elasticity Among Renters

[Back](#)[Regression](#)

Model: parents less income-elastic in housing ($\bar{h}(1) > \bar{h}(0)$).



Mean rooms among renters: 4.20 for childless households, 4.92 for parents.

- Parent renters start from a larger space baseline, but rooms rise less with income: elasticity 0.102 for parents versus 0.129 for childless renters.

Renter Housing-Demand Elasticity

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Outcome	Childless slope	Parent interaction	Parent slope
Log rooms	0.129*** (0.001)	−0.027*** (0.001)	0.102*** (0.001)
Metro FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Age and year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sex and race controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations		3,024,081	

Notes. OLS on ACS renters, ages 22–45, 2012–2023, weighted by perwt. Specification is $\log(\text{rooms})$ on $\log(\text{income})$, parent status, and the interaction, with metro, age, and year fixed effects plus sex and race controls. Standard errors in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$.

Potential Reasons to Move in the PSID Questionnaire

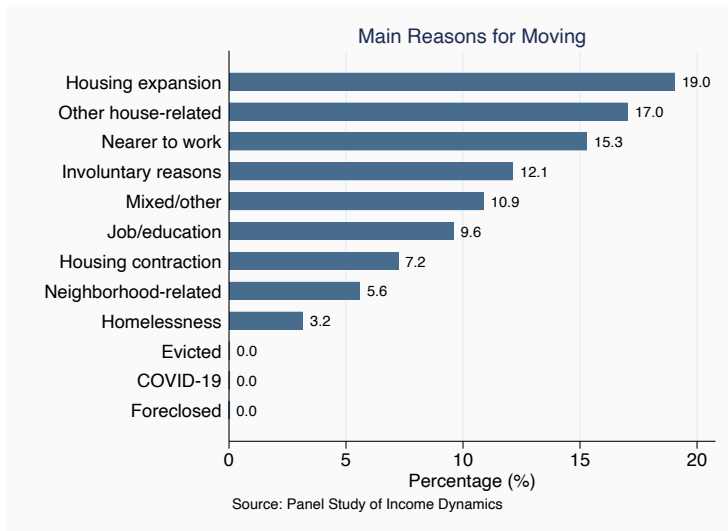
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Movers are asked: “What is the main reason you moved?”. Categories:

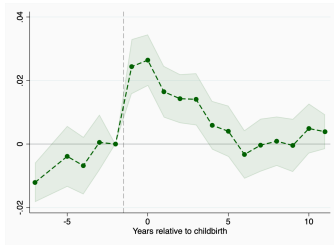
- **Purposive productive:** take another job; transfer; stopped going to school.
- **Nearer to work.**
- **Purposive consumptive — expansion of housing:** more space; higher rent; better place.
- **Purposive consumptive — contraction of housing:** less space; less rent.
- **Purposive consumptive — other house-related:** get own home; got married; physical condition of prior unit.
- **Purposive consumptive — neighborhood:** better neighborhood; schooling; closer to friends/relatives.
- **Involuntary:** housing unit coming down; armed services; health; divorce; forced retirement.
- **Ambiguous or mixed:** save money, neighbors moved away, retiring.
- Became homeless or no longer homeless; COVID-19; evicted / foreclosed.

Distribution of Reasons to Move Among Non-Parents

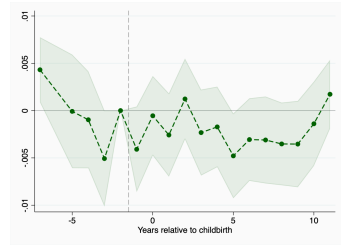
This tabulates values only for non-parents (both “never” and “not yet”).



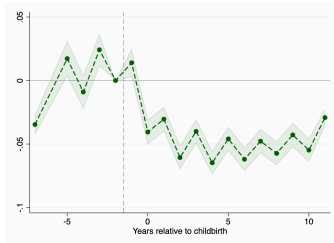
Event Studies: Housing and Location Reasons

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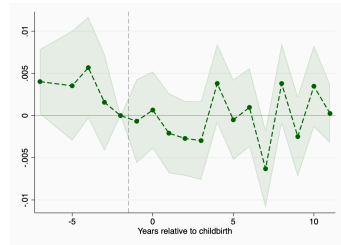
Expansion of housing



Contraction of housing

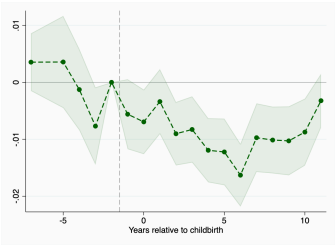


Other house-related

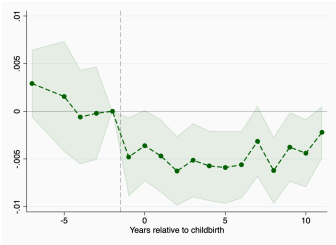


Neighborhood

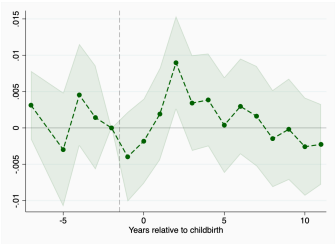
Event Studies: Work and Involuntary Reasons



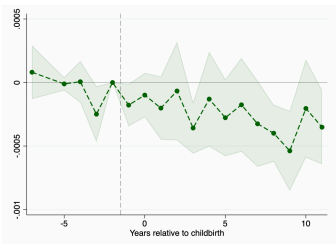
Productive reasons



To get nearer to work

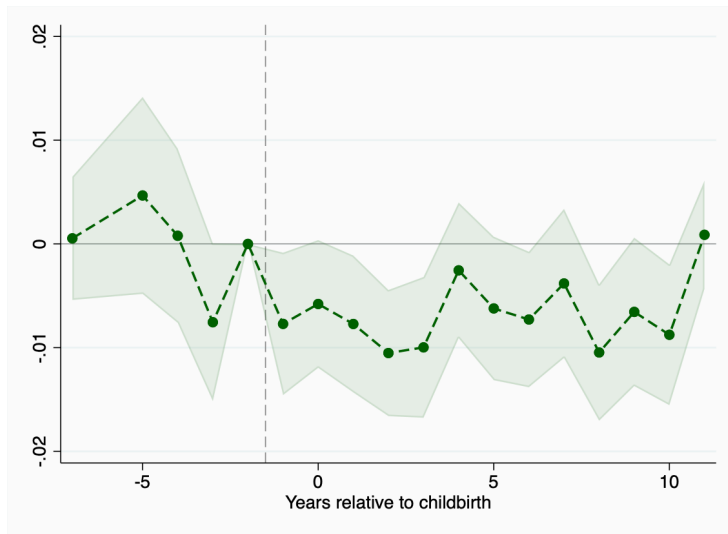


Involuntary reasons



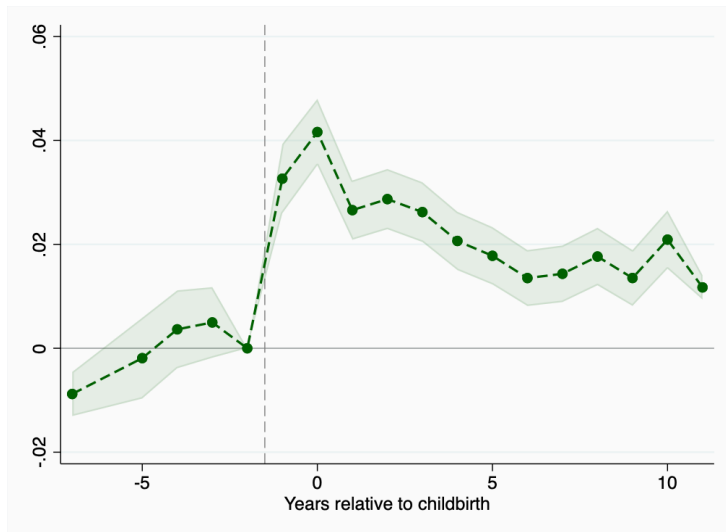
Was evicted

Event Studies: Other Reasons

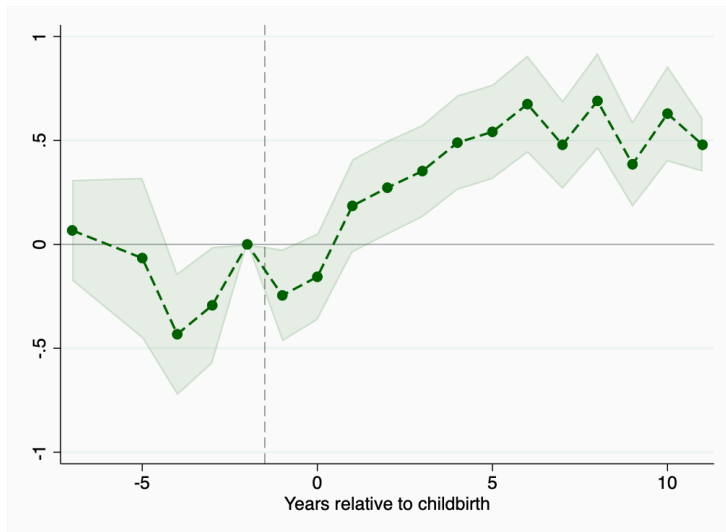


Mixed or other reasons

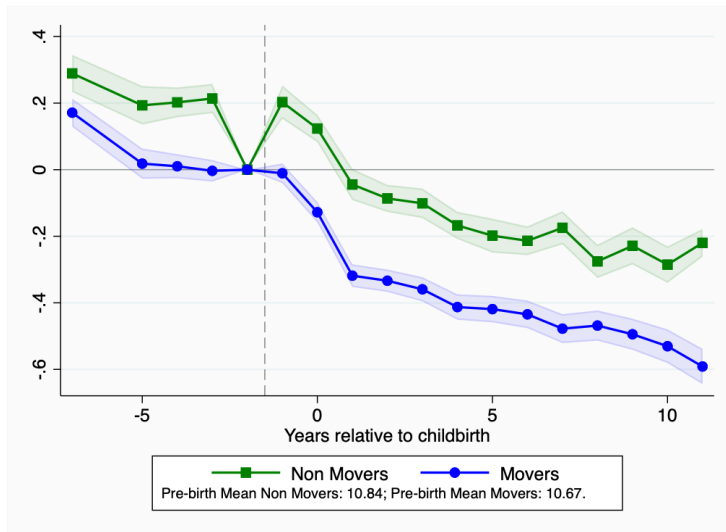
No Individual FE: Reasons to Move (Expansion of Housing)

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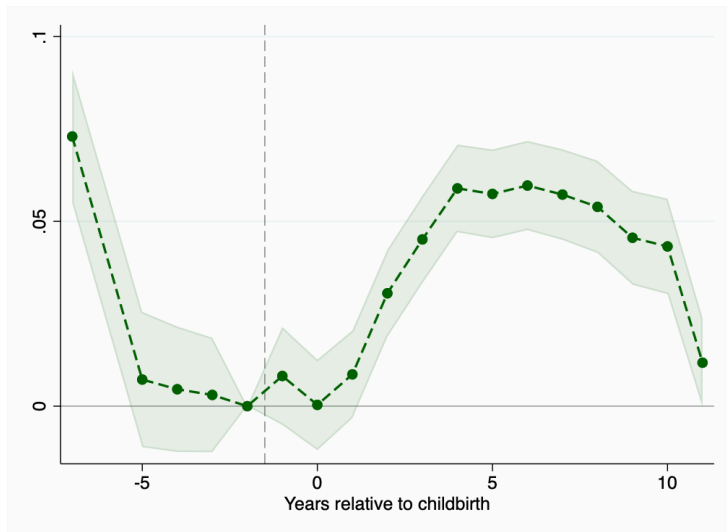
No Individual FE: Number of Rooms Around First Birth

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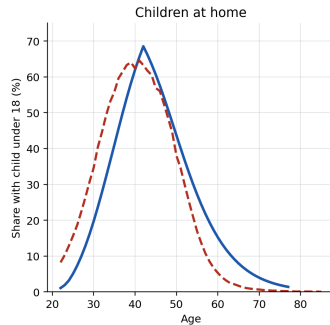
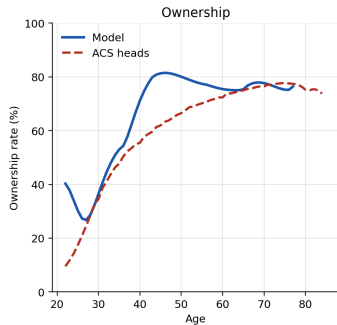
No Individual FE: Family Income Around First Birth

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No Individual FE: Homeownership Around First Birth

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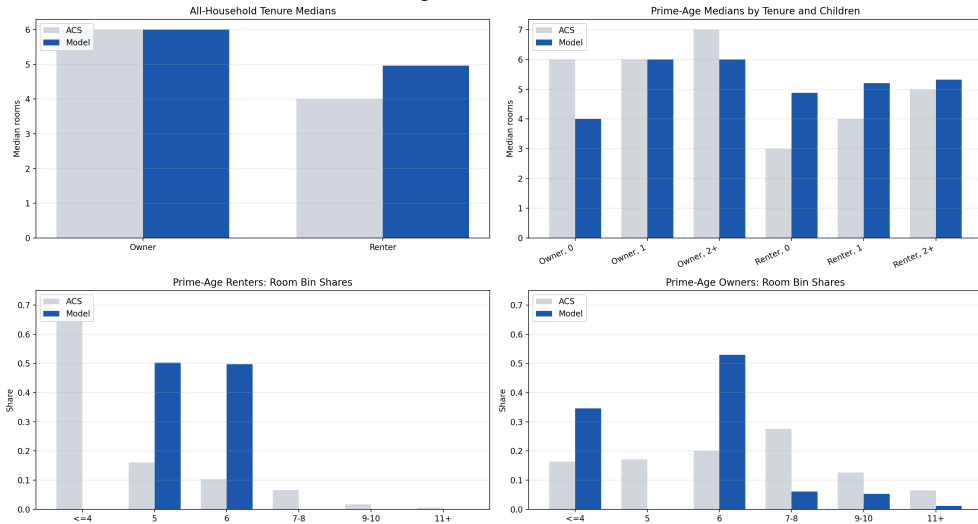
Appendix: Aggregate Lifecycle Full Wealth

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Housing Size Fit: Model vs Data

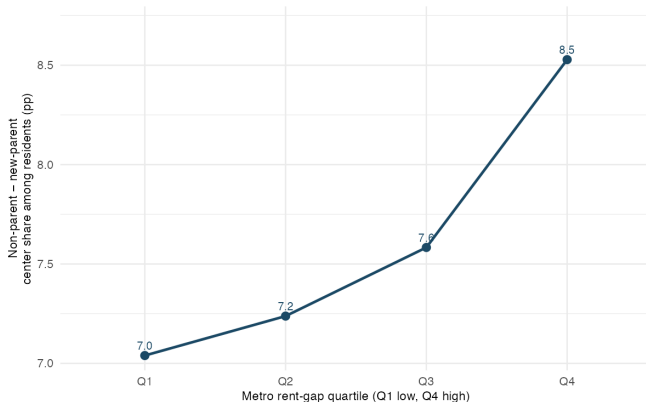
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Housing Size Fit: Model vs Data



Sorting Strength: Residents (Stock) [Back](#)

Model: parent share falls with local rent; $\partial \mathcal{W} / \partial r_C > 0$.



Y-axis: non-parent minus new-parent center share among all residents (pp). Base: 49.4% for non-parents, 41.6% for new parents.

- Stock-based sorting gap also rises with the rent gap, but the gradient is flatter than among movers.